

The American West

"It takes a thousand voices to tell a single story."

— NATIVE AMERICAN PROVERB

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did U.S. westward expansion affect different groups in the nation?

MAIN SELECTIONS

1 **Losing the West** · Joseph Bruchac INFORMATIONAL TEXT

2 **The Transcontinental Railroad** · Bruce Watson MAGAZINE ARTICLE

3 **Homesteading** · from Prairie Public Broadcasting MEDIA: VIDEO

4 **A Pioneer Sampler** · Barbara Greenwood (illus. Heather Collins) HISTORICAL FICTION

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B • Reading Comprehension (32)	p. 6
C • IB Critical Thinking (5)	p. 12
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Worksheet A — Vocabulary

Module 4 · The American West · Grade 5 · 30 Items

CCSS L.5.4 · L.5.5 · L.5.6

NAME _____ DATE _____

Directions. Read each question carefully. Watch out for tricky choices. Fill in the circle next to the BEST answer.

BIG IDEA WORDS

Q1 L.5.6

victory

When you achieve a **victory**, you —

- ☐ **A.** give up before the contest ends.
- ☐ **B.** draw a map of a new place.
- ☐ **C.** overcome a challenge or win against a competitor.
- ☐ **D.** forget the rules of a game.

Q2 L.5.6

native

A plant or animal that is **native** to a place —

- ☐ **A.** was born or first lived in that place.
- ☐ **B.** cannot live there for long.
- ☐ **C.** was brought there from far away.
- ☐ **D.** visits there only in winter.

Q3 L.5.5 TRAP

epic

An **epic** event is one that is —

- ☐ **A.** small and quickly forgotten.
- ☐ **B.** very large and impressive, and sometimes heroic.
- ☐ **C.** quiet and ordinary.
- ☐ **D.** dull and unimportant.

Q4 L.5.6

midland

The **midland** of a country is —

- ☐ **A.** the coast along the ocean.
- ☐ **B.** a tall mountain range.
- ☐ **C.** the border with another country.
- ☐ **D.** the middle part of the country.

CRITICAL VOCABULARY · LOSING THE WEST

Q5 L.5.5 TRAP

expansion

The **expansion** of the United States took it westward. When there is an **expansion**, something —

- ☐ **A.** gets bigger or is made to get bigger.
- ☐ **B.** shrinks down to a smaller size.
- ☐ **C.** stays exactly the same.
- ☐ **D.** disappears completely.

Q6 L.5.4

consisted

The territory **consisted** of many regions. If something **consisted** of certain items, it —

- ☐ **A.** was sold to other countries.
- ☐ **B.** was hidden from view.
- ☐ **C.** was destroyed by a storm.
- ☐ **D.** was made up of those things.

Q7 L.5.4

knowledge

Their land was sold without their **knowledge**. If you have **knowledge**, you have —

- ☐ **A.** a large amount of money.
- ☐ **B.** a piece of farming land.
- ☐ **C.** information or understanding about something.
- ☐ **D.** a long and tiring journey.

Q8 L.5.4

authorized

The law **authorized** the president to grant lands. If you **authorized** something, you —

- ☐ **A.** refused to allow it.
- ☐ **B.** gave a person or thing permission to do something.
- ☐ **C.** wrote a story about it.
- ☐ **D.** asked a question about it.

Q9 L.5.5 TRAP

hardships

The people endured great **hardships**. **Hardships** are —

- ☐ **A.** difficulties or suffering caused by not having enough of something.
- ☐ **B.** comforts and easy times.
- ☐ **C.** tools used to build a house.
- ☐ **D.** gifts given to a friend.

CRITICAL VOCABULARY · LOSING THE WEST (CONTINUED)

Q10 L.5.5 TRAP

typically

The land they were given was **typically** poor. **Typically** means that something —

- ☐ **A.** happens only once.
- ☐ **B.** is usually that way.
- ☐ **C.** never happens at all.
- ☐ **D.** is hard to explain.

Q11 L.5.4

alliance

Several nations formed an **alliance**. When people or groups are in an **alliance**, they —

- ☐ **A.** refuse to speak to one another.
- ☐ **B.** live very far apart.
- ☐ **C.** compete to see who is strongest.
- ☐ **D.** promise to work together to achieve a goal.

Q12 L.5.5 TRAP

abundant

The buffalo were once **abundant** on the plains. If something is **abundant**, there is —

- ☐ **A.** very little of it left.
- ☐ **B.** none of it at all.
- ☐ **C.** plenty, or a lot, of it available.
- ☐ **D.** only a single one of it.

CRITICAL VOCABULARY · THE TRANSCONTINENTAL RAILROAD

Q13 L.5.4

transcontinental

They built a **transcontinental** railroad. If something is **transcontinental**, it —

- ☐ **A.** goes across a continent.
- ☐ **B.** stays in one small town.
- ☐ **C.** floats across the ocean.
- ☐ **D.** is buried underground.

Q14 L.5.4

complaint

They worked long hours without a **complaint**. A **complaint** is —

- ☐ **A.** a happy cheer.
- ☐ **B.** a quiet song.
- ☐ **C.** an expression of dissatisfaction or pain.
- ☐ **D.** a list of directions.

Q15 L.5.4

employed

The railroad **employed** thousands of workers. If you **employed** people, you —

- ☐ **A.** sent them home for the day.
- ☐ **B.** taught them to read.
- ☐ **C.** traveled with them west.
- ☐ **D.** hired them to do a job.

Q16 L.5.4

sacrifice

Their labor and **sacrifice** joined the coasts. A **sacrifice** is —

- ☐ **A.** a reward you receive for winning.
- ☐ **B.** the act of giving up something valued for something or someone else.
- ☐ **C.** a quick and easy task.
- ☐ **D.** a tool used for digging.

CRITICAL VOCABULARY · HOMESTEADING

Q17 L.5.4

homestead

In the late 1800s, a **homestead** was —

- ☐ **A.** a piece of western land that was claimed, lived on, and settled by a pioneer.
- ☐ **B.** a large ship that crossed the ocean.
- ☐ **C.** a busy city in the East.
- ☐ **D.** a railroad station for trains.

Q18 L.5.4

primary

Land was the homesteader's **primary** goal. Something that is **primary** is —

- ☐ **A.** last in line.
- ☐ **B.** first in rank or the highest in importance.
- ☐ **C.** only a small detail.
- ☐ **D.** kept a secret from others.

CRITICAL VOCABULARY · HOMESTEADING (CONTINUED)

Q19 L.5.4

domain

The settler worked his own **domain**. Someone's **domain** is —

- ☐ **A.** a borrowed tool.
- ☐ **B.** a faraway city.
- ☐ **C.** the land or territory that he or she owns and controls.
- ☐ **D.** a kind of farm animal.

Q20 L.5.4

residence

They built a small **residence** on the prairie. A **residence** is —

- ☐ **A.** a place to store crops.
- ☐ **B.** a path through the fields.
- ☐ **C.** a kind of wagon.
- ☐ **D.** a place in which people live.

Q21 L.5.5 TRAP

ideology

The Homestead Act grew from an **ideology** about land. An **ideology** is —

- ☐ **A.** a set of beliefs.
- ☐ **B.** a single fact you can prove.
- ☐ **C.** a tool for measuring land.
- ☐ **D.** a place far out west.

CRITICAL VOCABULARY · A PIONEER SAMPLER

Q22 L.5.4

frolics

After the harvest came the **frolics**. **Frolics** are —

- ☐ **A.** long days of plowing.
- ☐ **B.** piles of cut wood.
- ☐ **C.** fun acts, such as dances or parties.
- ☐ **D.** tools for the barn.

Q23 L.5.4

stubble

The **stubble** prickled Willy's bare feet. **Stubble** is —

- ☐ **A.** soft, wet mud.
- ☐ **B.** the short, stiff stalks of plants that remain in a field after harvesting.
- ☐ **C.** tall, green grass.
- ☐ **D.** a pile of fresh hay.

Q24 L.5.5 TRAP

indispensable

George acted as though he were **indispensable**. Something that is **indispensable** is —

- ☐ **A.** easy to throw away.
- ☐ **B.** already broken.
- ☐ **C.** too heavy to carry.
- ☐ **D.** necessary.

Q25 L.5.4

dainty

A **dainty** pony skipped by. Something that is **dainty** is —

- ☐ **A.** huge and heavy.
- ☐ **B.** loud and noisy.
- ☐ **C.** delicate.
- ☐ **D.** old and dusty.

CRITICAL VOCABULARY · A PIONEER SAMPLER (CONTINUED)

Q26 L.5.5 TRAP

plod

The oxen began a steady **plod**. To **plod** is to —

- ☐ **A.** move heavily and slowly.
- ☐ **B.** run as fast as you can.
- ☐ **C.** leap high into the air.
- ☐ **D.** spin around in circles.

Q27 L.5.5 TRAP

oblivious

He was **oblivious** to everything but the haystack. If someone is **oblivious** to something, he or she is —

- ☐ **A.** closely watching it.
- ☐ **B.** unaware of it.
- ☐ **C.** afraid of it.
- ☐ **D.** excited about it.

Q28 L.5.4

proportions

It became a story of heroic **proportions**. When you talk about the **proportions** of something, you talk about its —

- ☐ **A.** color.
- ☐ **B.** price.
- ☐ **C.** age.
- ☐ **D.** size.

Q29 L.5.4

regaled

Willy **regaled** him with the whole tale. If you **regaled** someone, you —

- ☐ **A.** ignored them.
- ☐ **B.** argued with them.
- ☐ **C.** entertained them.
- ☐ **D.** forgot about them.

Q30 L.5.4

thresh

They needed time to **thresh** the wheat. To **thresh** a plant is to —

- ☐ **A.** beat it in order to separate its grain or seeds from the rest of the plant.
- ☐ **B.** water it every day.
- ☐ **C.** plant its seeds in a row.
- ☐ **D.** tie it into a tall bundle.



Worksheet B — Reading Comprehension

Module 4 · The American West · Grade 5 · 32 Items

CCSS RI.5.1 · RI.5.2 · RI.5.3 · RI.5.5 · RI.5.6 · RI.5.8 · RL.5.1 · RL.5.2 · RL.5.3 · RL.5.6

NAME _____ DATE _____

Directions. Use what you remember from each selection to answer the questions. Fill in the circle next to the BEST answer.

Selection 1 · Losing the West

INFORMATIONAL TEXT · JOSEPH BRUCHAC · 8 QUESTIONS

Q1 RI.5.2

What is "Losing the West" mostly about?

- ☐ A. How Chinese workers built the first railroad across the country, hanging from cliffs and blasting through the mountains.
- ☐ B. How pioneers claimed free land on the prairie and turned the open grass into farms and homes.
- ☐ C. How westward expansion harmed Native Americans, who lost their land, cultures, and ways of life.
- ☐ D. How a young pioneer named Willy worked with his family to save the harvest from the rain.

Q2 RI.5.3

According to the text, how did European Americans and Native Americans differ in the way they viewed land?

- ☐ A. Many European Americans saw land as something to own, while Native Americans saw it as a homeland shared by their people.
- ☐ B. Both groups agreed that no one should ever live on the land.
- ☐ C. Neither group cared about the land at all.
- ☐ D. Both groups wanted to sell the land to other countries.

Q3 RI.5.3

What was the Trail of Tears?

- ☐ A. A railroad line that crossed the plains.
- ☐ B. A river the settlers followed west.
- ☐ C. A celebration held after the Gold Rush.
- ☐ D. The forced winter journey on which the Cherokee were driven west, and thousands died.

Q4 RI.5.8

What evidence does the author give to show that the near loss of the buffalo was not an accident?

- ☐ **A.** The buffalo simply wandered away to a new land.
- ☐ **B.** The buffalo, once the most abundant large animal on the continent, were hunted toward extinction on purpose.
- ☐ **C.** The buffalo were never very many to begin with.
- ☐ **D.** The buffalo were carefully protected by everyone.

Q5 RI.5.5

How does the author mainly organize this informational text?

- ☐ **A.** With headings and a time order that show, step by step, how Native nations lost their land.
- ☐ **B.** As a set of rhyming poems.
- ☐ **C.** As a make-believe adventure story.
- ☐ **D.** As a single list of cooking steps.

Q6 RI.5.6

What is the author's main purpose in writing "Losing the West"?

- ☐ **A.** To explain, step by step, how settlers built sod houses and farmed the open prairie.
- ☐ **B.** To entertain readers with a make-believe adventure about a family's life in the Old West.
- ☐ **C.** To describe, in order, how the transcontinental railroad finally joined the east and west coasts.
- ☐ **D.** To inform readers about how westward expansion affected Native Americans and to share their side of the story.

Q7 RI.5.3

According to the text, what happened to many Native nations as the government helped settlers take more land?

- ☐ **A.** They grew larger and richer than before.
- ☐ **B.** They were left completely alone.
- ☐ **C.** They lost their people, culture, language, homelands, food sources, and ways of life.
- ☐ **D.** They moved to the eastern cities to live.

Q8 RI.5.2

Which sentence BEST states a central idea of "Losing the West"?

- ☐ **A.** The Louisiana Purchase of 1803 nearly doubled the size of the country's territory.
- ☐ **B.** Westward expansion was an opportunity for many Americans but a tragedy for the Native peoples who already lived there.
- ☐ **C.** The buffalo, once the most abundant large animal on the whole continent, were hunted toward extinction on purpose.
- ☐ **D.** Some Native leaders took their cases all the way to the courts to try to hold on to their land.

Selection 2 · The Transcontinental Railroad

MAGAZINE ARTICLE · BRUCE WATSON · 8 QUESTIONS

Q9 RI.5.2

What is "The Transcontinental Railroad" mostly about?

- ☐ **A.** The Chinese workers whose labor and sacrifice built the first railroad across the United States, though they were rarely recognized.
- ☐ **B.** The impact of westward expansion on Native nations, who lost their people, homelands, food sources, and ways of life.
- ☐ **C.** A pioneer family working through the harvest, where a boy longs to do "real work" like his brother.
- ☐ **D.** How the promise of free land drew homesteaders west to claim and improve 160 acres of prairie.

Q10 RI.5.8

What reason does the article give for why the Central Pacific hired so many Chinese workers?

- ☐ **A.** They were the only people who lived in California.
- ☐ **B.** They asked to work for no pay at all.
- ☐ **C.** They already owned the railroad company.
- ☐ **D.** When other workers were busy gold-mining or quit, Charles Crocker employed thousands of Chinese workers to keep the railroad going.

Q11 RI.5.3

According to the article, what was dangerous about the work the Chinese laborers did in the mountains?

- ☐ **A.** They had to drive the trains at high speed.
- ☐ **B.** They hung from ropes over cliffs and set off blasts to cut holes into the sides of mountains.
- ☐ **C.** They had to swim across deep rivers each day.
- ☐ **D.** They were asked to tame wild horses.

Q12 RI.5.5

How does the author mainly organize this magazine article?

- ☐ **A.** As a play with characters and scenes.
- ☐ **B.** As a list of cooking directions.
- ☐ **C.** In time order, telling how the railroad was built and finished, with photographs and captions.
- ☐ **D.** As a collection of poems.

Q13 RI.5.3

What happened at the ceremony where the two railroads were joined together?

- ☐ **A.** The Chinese workers were given the place of honor.
- ☐ **B.** The ceremony was canceled because of rain.
- ☐ **C.** No photographs were taken at all.
- ☐ **D.** When the cameras recorded the event, the Chinese workers were almost entirely left out of the picture.

Q14 RI.5.6

Why does the author point out that few people bothered to learn the Chinese workers' names?

- ☐ **A.** To show that these workers were treated unfairly and left out of the history, even though their work was essential.
- ☐ **B.** To explain how trains are built today.
- ☐ **C.** To show that the workers did not really do much.
- ☐ **D.** To prove that the railroad was never finished.

Q15 RI.5.1

Which detail from the article BEST supports the idea that the Chinese workers were hard workers?

- ☐ **A.** They traveled by ship to reach America.
- ☐ **B.** They had never seen a railroad before.
- ☐ **C.** They worked 12 hours straight without complaint.
- ☐ **D.** They lived near the city of Sacramento.

Q16 RI.5.2

Which sentence BEST states a central idea of this article?

- ☐ **A.** Once the railroad was finished, trains became a fast new way to travel all the way from one coast to the other.
- ☐ **B.** Chinese workers did essential, dangerous work to build the railroad, yet faced discrimination and were erased from the record.
- ☐ **C.** The Central Pacific company started its line in California and pushed east toward the plains.
- ☐ **D.** The mountains were hard to cross, so the crews had to blast tunnels through solid rock.

Selection 3 · Homesteading

MEDIA: VIDEO · FROM PRAIRIE PUBLIC BROADCASTING · 8 QUESTIONS

Q17 RI.5.2

What is this video mostly about?

- ☐ **A.** How Chinese workers built the first railroad across the country, yet were left out of the famous photograph and the history.
- ☐ **B.** How the Homestead Act gave western land to settlers willing to live on and improve it, and what homesteading life was like.
- ☐ **C.** How westward expansion harmed Native nations, who lost their land, cultures, and ways of life.
- ☐ **D.** How a boy named Willy saved a load of hay from the rain during the family's harvest.

Q18 RI.5.3

According to the video, what did the Homestead Act allow people to do?

- ☐ **A.** Ride the railroad for free.
- ☐ **B.** Buy land only in the eastern cities.
- ☐ **C.** Claim 160 acres of land in the West if they would live on it and improve it.
- ☐ **D.** Hunt buffalo on the open plains.

Q19 RI.5.6

Why does the video include a real homesteader's letter along with the narrator's explanation?

- ☐ **A.** To let viewers hear a firsthand voice from the time, not just a later summary of events.
- ☐ **B.** To prove that homesteading never really happened.
- ☐ **C.** To teach viewers how to write a letter.
- ☐ **D.** To show how to plow a field.

Q20 RI.5.3

According to the video, why did President Lincoln support giving land to homesteaders?

- ☐ **A.** He wanted the land to stay empty.
- ☐ **B.** He hoped people would move back east.
- ☐ **C.** He wanted only wealthy people to own land.
- ☐ **D.** He believed that as people succeeded on their own land, they would help develop America.

Q21 RI.5.5

How does the video mainly present its information?

- ☐ **A.** As a single rhyming poem.
- ☐ **B.** As a list of math problems.
- ☐ **C.** Through narration and images, with a primary-source letter and interviews with experts.
- ☐ **D.** As a make-believe fairy tale.

Q22 RI.5.3

According to the video, how were the Homestead Act and the railroads connected?

- ☐ **A.** The railroads made homesteading against the law.
- ☐ **B.** Both helped develop America by bringing people to the undeveloped parts of the West.
- ☐ **C.** The Homestead Act stopped the railroads from being built.
- ☐ **D.** The two had nothing to do with each other.

Q23 RI.5.6

What is the main purpose of this video?

- ☐ **A.** To entertain viewers with a make-believe story about a family living on the prairie.
- ☐ **B.** To convince people today to move west and buy land of their own.
- ☐ **C.** To explain how the transcontinental railroad was built across the mountains.
- ☐ **D.** To inform viewers about homesteading and how it helped settle the American West.

Q24 RI.5.2

Which sentence BEST states a central idea of this video?

- ☐ **A.** The Homestead Act drew pioneers west to claim free land, which demanded hard work and helped develop the country.
- ☐ **B.** President Lincoln supported the Homestead Act because he wanted people to have a chance at land.
- ☐ **C.** The video uses a real homesteader's letter to let viewers hear a voice from the past.
- ☐ **D.** The open prairie had very few trees, so settlers often built their houses out of sod.

Selection 4 · A Pioneer Sampler

HISTORICAL FICTION · BARBARA GREENWOOD (ILLUS. HEATHER COLLINS) · 8 QUESTIONS

Q25 RL.5.2

What is "A Pioneer Sampler" mostly about?

- ☐ **A.** How the first railroad across the country was built by Chinese workers who hung from cliffs.
- ☐ **B.** How westward expansion affected Native nations, who were driven from their homelands.
- ☐ **C.** A pioneer family's hard work during the harvest, told through young Willy, who longs to do "real work."
- ☐ **D.** How a homesteading family built a house of sod and broke the tough prairie soil.

Q26 RL.5.3

At the start of the story, why is Willy unhappy with the job he is given?

- ☐ **A.** He is afraid of the oxen.
- ☐ **B.** He has to carry water and wishes he could do "real work" like his older brother, George.
- ☐ **C.** He does not like the hot weather.
- ☐ **D.** He wants to go to school instead.

Q27 RL.5.3

How does Willy finally prove himself during the harvest?

- ☐ **A.** He steers the oxen and saves a load of hay before the rain can ruin it.
- ☐ **B.** He wins a race against George.
- ☐ **C.** He builds a new barn by himself.
- ☐ **D.** He sells the wheat at the market.

Q28 RL.5.1

Which detail BEST shows that Pa is proud of Willy at the end?

- ☐ **A.** Pa sends Willy back to carry more water.
- ☐ **B.** Pa says nothing to Willy at all.
- ☐ **C.** Pa tells Willy to ask George for help.
- ☐ **D.** Pa says, "You saved that load. You've got a real farmer's eye for weather."

Q29 RL.5.2

What lesson, or theme, does the story share about pioneer life?

- ☐ **A.** Pioneer life took constant hard work, and every member of the family — even a young child — had a part to play.
- ☐ **B.** Pioneer children spent most of their days at play and were never once asked to help with the chores.
- ☐ **C.** A pioneer farm mostly ran itself, so the harvest came in without much effort from anyone.
- ☐ **D.** On a pioneer farm it was always best to finish every job completely on your own.

Q30 **RL.5.6**

From whose point of view is most of the story told?

- ☐ **A.** From the point of view of the oxen.
- ☐ **B.** From Pa's point of view.
- ☐ **C.** Mostly through Willy's eyes, so readers share his feelings and his wish to do "real work."
- ☐ **D.** From the point of view of Uncle Jacob.

Q31 **RL.5.3**

Why does the author include the family motto, "Eat it up, wear it out, make it do, or do without"?

- ☐ **A.** To show that the family wasted everything they had.
- ☐ **B.** To show that pioneer families had to be careful and make do with what little they had.
- ☐ **C.** To explain how trains were built.
- ☐ **D.** To prove that the family was very rich.

Q32 **RL.5.2** **TRAP**

Which sentence BEST states the theme of "A Pioneer Sampler"?

- ☐ **A.** Willy carries water in two buckets to the workers out in the hayfield.
- ☐ **B.** George, the older brother, gets to cut the hay while Willy does the "baby work."
- ☐ **C.** While the family works, a dainty pony skips by in the clouds above the haystack.
- ☐ **D.** Through hard work and cooperation, even a young pioneer can prove that he is needed by his family.



Worksheet C — IB Critical Thinking

Module 4 · The American West · Grade 5

IB PYP Key Concepts · DOK 2 – 4

NAME _____ DATE _____

Directions. Use what you learned from each selection to think more deeply about how westward expansion changed the lives of different groups. Each question helps you grow as an IB learner.

Q1 **Perspective** **DOK 3**

In "**Losing the West**," Joseph Bruchac shows how two groups saw the same land very differently. Show EACH view, then explain why hearing the Native American side matters.

TWO VIEWS OF THE LAND · LOSING THE WEST

HOW MANY SETTLERS SAW THE LAND

HOW NATIVE AMERICANS SAW THE LAND

Why is it important to hear the Native American side of this history? Use the word *expansion* in your answer.

Q2

Causation

DOK 3

In "**The Transcontinental Railroad**," Chinese workers did essential, dangerous work, yet they were left out of the story. Show the CAUSE and the EFFECT, then explain what was unfair.

WORK AND RECOGNITION · THE TRANSCONTINENTAL RAILROAD

WHAT THE CHINESE WORKERS DID



HOW THEY WERE TREATED

Why was it unfair that the workers were left out of the picture? Use the word *sacrifice* in your answer.

Q3

Change

DOK 3

In "**Homesteading**," the Homestead Act changed the American West. Show the STEPS, then explain what a homesteader had to do to keep the land.

HOW HOMESTEADING WORKED · HOMESTEADING

THE LAW

what did the Homestead Act offer?

WHAT PEOPLE DID

how did settlers respond?

THE RESULT

how did the West change?

A homestead was free, but not easy to keep. Why did it take so much hard work? Use the word *homestead* in your answer.

In "**A Pioneer Sampler**," young Willy wants to do "real work" and finally proves himself. Show the PROBLEM and how he SOLVES it, then explain what the story shows about pioneer families.

WILLY PROVES HIMSELF · A PIONEER SAMPLER

WILLY'S PROBLEM AT THE START

HOW WILLY PROVES HIMSELF

What does the story show about how pioneer families had to work together? Explain using one detail from the story.

Essential Question: How did U.S. westward expansion affect different groups in the nation? Use ideas from TWO of the selections in this module to answer.

TWO-SELECTION SYNTHESIS

SELECTION 1 · TITLE

Which group does it show, and how did westward expansion affect them?

SELECTION 2 · TITLE

Which group does it show, and how did westward expansion affect them?

MY BIG IDEA



Worksheet D — MAP Practice

Module 4 · The American West · Grade 5

MAP RIT 205 → 225 · 4 Mini-Passages × 5 Questions

NAME _____ DATE _____

Directions. Read each short passage carefully. Then answer the 5 questions that follow. Each passage is NEW — not from the selections in this workbook.

Passage 1 · The Long Walk Home

Tahki had heard the old people speak of the land before the wagons came. Back then, her grandmother said, the prairie stretched on forever, and great herds of buffalo darkened the grass like a moving shadow. The people did not own the land the way a farmer owns a field. They belonged to it, the way a child belongs to a family. Then the settlers arrived, fence by fence, and the herds grew thin. One cold morning, soldiers came to Tahki's village with an order. The people were told to leave the valley where their families had lived for longer than anyone could count. They were to walk to a new place, far away, that the government had chosen for them. Tahki carried her little brother on her back. The walk was long and the winter was cruel, and not everyone who started the journey reached the end. But at night, the elders still told the old stories around the fire, so the children would remember who they were. "They can move us," Tahki's grandmother whispered, "but they cannot take our memory. As long as we tell the stories, we are still a people."

194 WORDS · LEXILE 620–700L · RIT 205–211

Q1

RIT 205

Lexile 620L

Key Detail

According to Tahki's grandmother, how did the people feel about the land long ago?

- ☐ **A.** They wanted to sell it for money.
- ☐ **B.** They belonged to it, the way a child belongs to a family.
- ☐ **C.** They were afraid to walk on it.
- ☐ **D.** They never went near it.

Q2

RIT 207

Lexile 640L

Cause & Effect

What happened to the buffalo herds after the settlers arrived?

- ☐ **A.** They grew much larger.
- ☐ **B.** They moved into the village.
- ☐ **C.** They grew thin, fence by fence.
- ☐ **D.** They were never seen again that very day.

Q3 RIT 208 Lexile 660L Key Detail

Why did the soldiers come to Tahki's village?

- ☐ A. To help the people plant crops.
- ☐ B. To bring food for the winter.
- ☐ C. To tell stories around the fire.
- ☐ D. To order the people to leave their valley and walk to a new place.

Q4 RIT 210 Lexile 685L Inference

Why do the elders keep telling the old stories at night?

- ☐ A. So the children will remember who they are, even far from home.
- ☐ B. Because they have nothing else to do.
- ☐ C. To help everyone fall asleep faster.
- ☐ D. To pass the time until the wagons return.

Q5 RIT 211 Lexile 700L Theme

What is the main message, or theme, of this passage?

- ☐ A. Winter is the hardest season to travel, and a long walk in the cold is dangerous.
- ☐ B. When soldiers give an order, the wisest thing a village can do is obey it quietly.
- ☐ C. A people can lose their land but still hold on to who they are through their memories and stories.
- ☐ D. The great herds of buffalo once darkened the prairie grass like a moving shadow.

Passage 2 · Driving the Golden Spike

For seven years, two railroad companies raced toward each other across the middle of the country. One crew laid track eastward from California, while the other pushed westward from the plains. The work was brutal. Crews blasted tunnels through solid granite, built wooden bridges over deep canyons, and laid heavy iron rails mile after mile. In the steep mountains, much of the most dangerous work was done by Chinese laborers, who were lowered in baskets to chip away at the rock. Through burning summers and freezing winters, the two armies of workers crept closer. On May 10, 1869, they finally met at a dusty spot in Utah called Promontory Summit. A crowd gathered to watch as the last spike, made of gold, was tapped into place to join the two lines. For the first time, a person could travel from one coast to the other in days instead of months. Newspapers called it one of the great wonders of the age. Yet in the famous photograph taken that day, the thousands of Chinese workers who had made the railroad possible were almost nowhere to be seen. The country celebrated the railroad, but it often forgot the hands that had built it.

201 WORDS · LEXILE 740–840L · RIT 211–217

Q6 RIT 211 Lexile 740L Key Detail

What were the two railroad companies doing?

- ☐ **A.** Racing toward each other to lay track across the country.
- ☐ **B.** Building a single station in California.
- ☐ **C.** Digging for gold in Utah.
- ☐ **D.** Painting bridges over the canyons.

Q7 RIT 213 Lexile 770L Key Detail

According to the passage, what dangerous work did Chinese laborers do in the steep mountains?

- ☐ **A.** They drove the first trains.
- ☐ **B.** They were lowered in baskets to chip away at the rock.
- ☐ **C.** They painted the golden spike.
- ☐ **D.** They sold tickets to the crowd.

Q8 RIT 214 Lexile 800L Cause & Effect

What changed once the railroad was finished?

- ☐ **A.** The mountains became flat.
- ☐ **B.** The two companies became one town.
- ☐ **C.** A person could travel from one coast to the other in days instead of months.
- ☐ **D.** The golden spike turned into iron.

Q9 RIT 215 Lexile 820L Vocabulary

The passage says the work was **brutal**. The word **brutal** means —

- ☐ **A.** easy and pleasant.
- ☐ **B.** short and simple.
- ☐ **C.** quiet and restful.
- ☐ **D.** very harsh and hard.

Q10 RIT 217 Lexile 840L Main Idea

What is the main idea of "Driving the Golden Spike"?

- ☐ **A.** The railroad was a great achievement, but the Chinese workers who built it were often forgotten.
- ☐ **B.** The last spike driven in at Promontory Summit was made of gold instead of iron.
- ☐ **C.** The two railroad companies finally met at a dusty spot in Utah after seven years.
- ☐ **D.** Once the railroad was done, a trip between the coasts took days instead of months.

When the Hansen family reached their claim on the open plains, they found no trees, no streams, and no neighbors — only a wide sea of grass that ran to the edge of the sky. They had come west because the government promised free land to anyone who would live on it and farm it for five years. But the prairie was a hard place to build a home. There was almost no wood. So, like many homesteaders, the Hansens cut blocks of thick prairie sod, the top layer of soil held together by tangled grass roots, and stacked them like bricks to make the walls of a house. They laid more sod across a frame of poles to make the roof. Their "soddy" was dark and cramped, and after a heavy rain, mud sometimes dripped from the ceiling for days. In summer the thick walls kept the house cool, and in winter they held in the heat. Snakes and insects were unwelcome guests. Still, it was a start. Year by year, the Hansens broke the tough sod with a plow, planted wheat, and dug a well. Slowly, the empty claim became a farm, and the farm became a home.

199 WORDS · LEXILE 760–860L · RIT 217–222

Q11 RIT 217 Lexile 760L Key Detail

Why did the Hansen family come west?

- ☐ A. To work on the railroad.
- ☐ B. To visit their neighbors.
- ☐ C. Because the government promised free land to anyone who would live on it and farm it for five years.
- ☐ D. To hunt buffalo on the plains.

Q12 RIT 218 Lexile 790L Cause & Effect

Why did the Hansens build their house out of sod instead of wood?

- ☐ A. They thought sod looked nicer.
- ☐ B. Wood was against the rules.
- ☐ C. They wanted a dark house.
- ☐ D. There was almost no wood on the open plains.

Q13 RIT 219 Lexile 820L Key Detail

What is "sod," according to the passage?

- ☐ A. The top layer of soil held together by tangled grass roots.
- ☐ B. A kind of wooden brick.
- ☐ C. A tool used to dig a well.
- ☐ D. A heavy winter coat.

Q14 RIT 220 Lexile 840L Author's Purpose

Why does the author describe both the good and the bad parts of the soddy?

- ☐ A. To prove that the plains had many trees.
- ☐ B. To show that homesteading was difficult but that the family kept working to make a home.
- ☐ C. To explain how to build a railroad.
- ☐ D. To tell readers to avoid the West.

Q15 RIT 222 Lexile 860L Main Idea

What is the main idea of "A Roof of Earth"?

- ☐ **A.** A sod house was dark and cramped and dripped mud after a rain, but its thick walls kept out the summer heat and winter cold.
- ☐ **B.** The open plains were full of snakes and insects that crept into the homesteaders' houses.
- ☐ **C.** With hard work and clever use of the land, a homesteading family slowly turned an empty claim into a farm and a home.
- ☐ **D.** Because there was almost no wood on the plains, the Hansens built their walls from blocks of sod.

Passage 4 · Manifest Destiny

In the middle of the 1800s, a powerful idea swept across the United States. Many people came to believe that the nation was meant to stretch all the way from the Atlantic Ocean to the Pacific Ocean. This belief was given a name: Manifest Destiny. The word "manifest" means clear or obvious, and "destiny" means a future that is meant to be. To those who believed in it, spreading west was not just a choice — it was the country's rightful path. Newspapers printed maps of the wide western lands, and speakers urged families to pack their wagons and go. Spurred on by this idea, hundreds of thousands of settlers traveled west in search of land, gold, and a fresh start. To the U.S. government and the settlers, the growth of the country looked like a great success. But Manifest Destiny had another side. The lands the settlers crossed and claimed were not empty. They were the homelands of many Native nations, who were pushed aside, moved onto reservations, or harmed as the settlers poured in. The same idea that promised opportunity to one group brought deep loss to another. History, it turns out, often depends on who is telling the story.

201 WORDS · LEXILE 860–960L · RIT 219–225

Q16 RIT 219 Lexile 860L Vocabulary

According to the passage, what does the term **Manifest Destiny** mean?

- ☐ **A.** A law that banned travel to the West.
- ☐ **B.** The belief that the nation was meant to stretch from the Atlantic Ocean to the Pacific Ocean.
- ☐ **C.** A kind of wagon used by settlers.
- ☐ **D.** A map of the eastern states.

Q17 RIT 220 Lexile 890L Cause & Effect

How did the idea of Manifest Destiny affect settlers?

- ☐ **A.** It convinced most of them to stay in the East.
- ☐ **B.** It spurred hundreds of thousands of them to travel west in search of land, gold, and a fresh start.
- ☐ **C.** It made them afraid of the western lands.
- ☐ **D.** It had no effect on where people lived.

Q18 RIT 221 Lexile 910L Key Detail

What was the "other side" of Manifest Destiny that the passage describes?

- ☐ **A.** The settlers ran out of wagons.
- ☐ **B.** The newspapers stopped printing maps.
- ☐ **C.** The gold was harder to find than expected.
- ☐ **D.** The western lands were the homelands of Native nations, who were pushed aside and harmed.

Q19 RIT 223 Lexile 935L Author's Purpose

Why does the author end by saying that history "often depends on who is telling the story"?

- ☐ **A.** To show that the same event can look like success to one group and loss to another.
- ☐ **B.** To prove that no one really moved west.
- ☐ **C.** To explain how to draw a map.
- ☐ **D.** To show that newspapers are never correct.

Q20 RIT 225 Lexile 960L Main Idea

What is the main idea of "Manifest Destiny"?

- ☐ **A.** Newspapers in the 1800s printed maps of the wide western lands, and speakers urged families to pack up and go.
- ☐ **B.** Spurred on by the idea, hundreds of thousands of settlers packed their wagons and rolled west in search of land, gold, and a fresh start.
- ☐ **C.** The word "manifest" means clear or obvious, and the word "destiny" means a future that is meant to be.
- ☐ **D.** The belief in Manifest Destiny drove settlers west and looked like success, but it brought deep loss to the Native nations already living there.